

tools do allow external integration of charts, they often forgo other functionalities such as exporting, email scheduling, etc.

These limited charting options affect companies or people who are looking for advanced functionalities, like data scientists and statisticians looking for statistical and advanced charting. A BI tool should allow charts to be integrated inside the report, dashboard, ad hoc, etc, with the capability to define inter-panel communication, input filters, etc. Also, even if integration of charts is external, other functionalities such as emailing, exporting, trigger, etc, should work well.

4. Reports and dashboards are clichéd.... but I don't have more options

Apart from the plain vanilla reports and dashboards, a BI tool should be future-ready enough for other visualisation options like infographics, what-if analysis, mash-ups, cubes, scorecards, or any other type which currently exists or might come up in the future.

5. The BI software UI looks so very alien!

Often, companies have their own products/software with certain navigation options, icons and colours, adhering to a chosen theme. With BI also being introduced to their solutions stack, wouldn't it be wonderful if the BI tool could be customised to match the design template of their existing solution stack? This would imply having the option to change the navigation, repository access, icons, content menu, colour, text, theme, file extensions, etc, of the BI software as well. Such exhaustive white-labelling capabilities can lead to a unified view of all the enterprise applications, leading to ease of branding, usage and viewing.

Currently, what most BI tools offer in the name of white labelling is changes in the header and footer design, colour and text—basically, very limited options.

6. There are so many tools I am compelled to use in a particular piece of BI software

Many of the BI tools require separate software and hardware to be used, such as the server, the designer tool, plugins, community plugins, etc. BI companies release enhancements within these, which at times, lead to compatibility issues. Here's food for thought: What if, using the browser itself, we are able to execute everything exactly in the way the BI solution is being accessed? Imagine—no more downloading heavy software, no more compatibility issues or separate purchase of tools, etc.

7. BI vendor engagement never seems to end – and so is the case with their billing!

Licensing presents complex issues. It may be based on the core, the number of users, the server, a combination of the above, or on data size. Also, there generally are separate licences for separate tools like the designer, server, plugin, etc. Sluggish performance of the solution leads to an increase in the number of cores and servers, and hence the more number of licences. Maintenance costs, development costs and renewal

costs are top-ups. Prices are not benchmarked and, in many cases, pricing is not crystal clear and often depends on the sales person and the bargain being struck.

8. Ad hoc capabilities are limited

Ad hoc capabilities allow business users to drag, drop and create their own reports and dashboards. Many BI tools are extremely limited here, not allowing or extending features to write custom scripts, add HTML, visualisation, custom calculated columns, etc.

9. Can I extend core functionality altogether?

All BI tools fail miserably in their ability to extend core functionality. BI tools are designed with the approach that one size fits all, wherein they sell only generic features. However, every client has a unique requirement. The ability to extend functionality and add features is something that could change the way people view and use BI. Examples of extending functionality could be things like an outlook plugin of BI, offline viewing, introducing new exporting options, a rule-based system, custom alerting notifications and triggers, custom business processes, etc. This could lead to a paradigm shift in the entire scope of BI. Frankly, the sky isn't the limit!

10. I wish I could define the sequence of events

An integrated workflow inside a BI tool could help in defining business processes and thus enhance capabilities. Examples of workflow could be things like: *run ETL AND create report AND mail to one set of users when value is between 0-50%, AND send it to other set of users when value is greater than 50%.*

11. So much software, so many screens

Companies generally use lots of software; so a client has to navigate through it based on requirements. Right now, we can only integrate BI charts inside other applications. It would be a real value addition if the BI tool is flexible enough to allow integration of other software inside the tool, interacts with this software too, and directly invokes its functions as well!

12. I just can't find BI resource people

Skilled resource personnel is a pressing problem in the BI domain. Resource persons are far too few and the salary they command is far too much, leading to outsourcing of the projects. Why should there be a separate set of resource persons for BI at all? Why can't BI tools be simple enough for a HTML/Java resource person to be able to work on the tool?

Do these situations sound familiar to you? Do you agree with the solutions? If you are able to connect with this situation, you may need to relook at your BI tool or BI implementation! 

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